

Meet the expert

Dr Amy Donovan works at the Department of Geography, King's College London in the UK. Her special interest is studying how science can help communities deal with the problems of living near active volcanoes. Dr Donovan also gives talks to schools and at science festivals, and writes for science journals.



Q: We know your job has something to do with geography, particularly hazards, such as volcanoes and earthquakes, but what exactly do you do?

A: Mostly my work involves using scientific and other kinds of information to make decisions about land use and population management around active volcanoes. At the moment, I'm working on how different countries can work together to manage the effects of eruptions.

Q: What made you decide to study geography, and specialize in the problems caused by volcanoes and earthquakes?

A: My first degree was in English, but geography and geology had always been strong interests of mine, so I decided to study geoscience with the Open University. Then I did a MSc in geophysical hazards, and finally a PhD in volcanology!

Q: What is a typical day at work like for you?

A: I work in a university, so I spend a lot of time teaching. But I also have days when I'm out monitoring an active volcano, or gathering information from other scientists and civil protection officials. I might also spend time with people affected by volcanic activity to find out how they deal with the problems that brings. Other days may be spent in the laboratory, studying samples of



Special protective clothing is worn around volcanoes.